

Canada: The Country That's Bigger Than Your Whole Weekend!

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Canada is hugeso huge it stretches across six **time zones**! From east to west, it's almost 4,700 miles wide. But here's the funny part: even though it's the second largest country in the world, only about one-half of one percent of all people live there. That means you could drive for hours and see more moose than humans!

Canada is like many countries in one. In the north, it's freezing Arctic land where **Inuit** people hunt and fish. In the middle, you'll find sparkling blue lakes and ancient rocks. In the west, towering mountains touch the sky. And in the east, forests and valleys roll on forever.

Wildlife is everywhere. Bears, wolves, beavers, and **bighorn sheep** roam the land. Canada's lakes and rivers hold about 20 percent of all the fresh water on Earthimagine that! Fish like trout and salmon splash around, and on the **prairies**, bison and antelope graze.

People in Canada speak English and French, and many **First Nations** people keep their traditions alive. Even though Canada has a king (the **British monarch**), it makes its own laws. And get this: Quebec almost voted to become its own country twice! Canada is full of big spaces, big animals, and big stories.

Word Treasure

time zones -- Time zones are divisions of the Earth where clocks show different hours because the sun rises at different times.

Inuit -- Inuit are an indigenous people living in the cold Arctic regions of Canada and Greenland.

bighorn sheep -- Bighorn sheep are wild sheep with big curved horns that live in the mountains of western Canada.

prairies -- Prairies are huge areas of flat grassland where bison and antelope live.

First Nations -- First Nations are the original peoples of Canada who lived there long before Europeans arrived.

British monarch -- The British monarch is the king or queen of the United Kingdom, who also serves as Canada's symbolic head of state.

Background you need

Canada is the second largest country in the world by land area, but its population of about 38 million is small for its size -- that's less than one-half of one percent of the world's people.

Indigenous groups like the Inuit and First Nations have lived on this land for thousands of years, long before Canada became a country in 1867.

Canada is a constitutional monarchy: the British monarch (currently King Charles III) is the official head of state, but the elected Parliament makes the laws.

Quebec is a French-speaking province with a unique culture; it has held votes in 1980 and 1995 on whether to become an independent country, but both times the 'no' side won.

Break it down

WHO: Canada, the second largest country on Earth

WHAT: A vast land with six time zones, tiny population, diverse landscapes, wildlife, and a mix of English, French, and indigenous cultures

WHERE: In North America, stretching from the Atlantic Ocean to the Pacific Ocean and up to the Arctic circle

WHY: To show how huge and varied Canada is, from its natural wonders and animals to its people and their stories

Why it matters

Canada holds one-fifth of the world's fresh water and is home to many different cultures, just like your own community might have people from many backgrounds sharing the same space.

Test what you remember

1. How many time zones does Canada stretch across?
 - (A) Four
 - (B) Five
 - (C) Six
 - (D) Seven
2. What percentage of the world's fresh water is in Canada?
 - (A) 10%
 - (B) 20%
 - (C) 5%
 - (D) 50%
3. Which people hunt and fish in the Arctic north of Canada?
 - (A) First Nations
 - (B) Inuit
 - (C) Métis
 - (D) Vikings
4. What two languages do most Canadians speak?
 - (A) English and Spanish
 - (B) English and French
 - (C) French and German
 - (D) English and Chinese
5. Which province almost voted to become a separate country twice?
 - (A) Ontario
 - (B) Quebec
 - (C) British Columbia
 - (D) Alberta
6. Which animal might you see more often than people in some parts of Canada?
 - (A) Polar bear
 - (B) Moose
 - (C) Beaver
 - (D) Wolf

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Outdoor enthusiast:** Canada's huge forests, sparkling lakes, and towering mountains are a dream for hiking, fishing, and seeing wildlife like bears and moose.
- 2. Indigenous cultural keeper:** Inuit and First Nations people have traditions stretching back thousands of years, and they work to keep their languages and ways of life strong.
- 3. Quebec independence supporter:** Some Quebec residents feel their French-speaking culture is so unique that they should govern themselves as a separate nation.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):